

Are Fewer Elections Better Elections? The Impact of On-Cycle Elections on the Electoral Experience*

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Abstract

Over the past decade, states around the country have moved to consolidate different elections to the same date. Despite this shifting landscape, we know little about what these reforms mean for the electoral process itself. Consolidating local elections with federal and statewide contests could make life easier for both voters and election administrators. But putting contests together could also put stress on the electoral process by asking voters to process a longer ballot and administrators to run different types of contests simultaneously. Utilizing original panel data on election timing and administrative and survey data, we find that switching to on-cycle elections saves money, reduces the burden on election officials, and has a limited impact on election quality. The one downside we observe—a small increase in voter wait times—could be addressed by redirecting some of the cost savings toward making voting easier.

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1 Introduction

America is changing the way it elects its leaders. Over ninety percent of its elected officials serve in local offices (Lawless 2012). And until recently, the vast majority of these local officials were elected on days when the only positions up for election were at the local level.

But that is shifting. In a little over a decade, six states – including two of the most populous – have moved to consolidated elections with local contests occurring on the same day as state level and federal offices. Over the last few decades, the share of local offices that are elected on these on-cycle dates has doubled (de Benedictis-Kessner et al. 2023; Hartney and Hayes 2021).¹ The share of on-cycle elections is likely to increase even more going forward. Twenty-nine states introduced election consolidation legislation last legislative cycle, and a dozen states enacted consolidating laws (Guzman 2025).

Previous studies have shown that moving local elections on-cycle has a number of benefits. It has a dramatic impact on voter turnout – doubling or more than doubling participation in local contests (Anzia 2013; de Benedictis-Kessner et al. 2023; Marschall and Lappie 2025). Research also shows that the move radically impacts the composition of the vote, making the electorate much younger, more racially diverse, and less skewed by class and wealth (de Benedictis-Kessner et al. 2023; Hajnal, Kogan, and Markarian 2022; Kogan, Lavertu, and Peskowitz 2018).

Moving on-cycle also saves money and is popular. Moving all of a state’s local offices to the same dates as statewide contests could save most of what authorities spend on these elections (Durning 2023). Additionally, surveys regularly show that two-thirds of Americans favor voting in one election on one day rather than voting in multiple elections across multiple different days (Anzia 2013; Ketcham and Severns 2024). Critically, that support is nonpartisan, with clear majorities of Republicans, Democrats, and Independents all favoring the move. In America’s polarized political environment, that cross-party agreement is rare.

¹Change has been substantial at the mayoral and school board level as well (Anzia 2013; de Benedictis-Kessner et al. 2023).

It is also part of the reason why states across the political spectrum have enacted election consolidation reforms and why further consolidation remains viable in almost every state.

But the on-cycle move also raises an important question. Putting all or most of America's elections on the same day on the same ballot raises concerns about the electoral process itself. Skeptics worry that voters and election officials will not be able to handle a longer ballot that includes a wide range of contests for different jurisdictions at different levels of office (Smith 2026). For voters, a longer, more complicated ballot could lead to longer stays in the voting booth and longer lines at the polls. For election administrators, more voters and more contests on the same date could create extra burdens that could ultimately lead to a less efficient voting experience and increased chances for administrative errors in ballot design and vote tabulation. In short, the election experience could get worse.

Yet, there are also reasons to expect election consolidation to not harm or even improve elections for voters and administrators. Advocates argue that fewer election dates should lead to smoother election administration. With fewer dates on the electoral cycle each year, election administrators should not have to prepare for as many different rounds of elections. That reduced burden could enable them to invest more time and effort into each individual election date. Election timing consolidation could also be more efficient for voters, who could do all of their voting at once, rather than voting multiple times across multiple dates. In short, the electoral experience could improve.

How does holding local elections concurrently with state and federal elections affect America's elections? Does putting more contests on the same date lead to longer wait times, more mistakes, and declines in quality or does consolidation instead result in a more efficient electoral process? Despite growing attention to election timing, we know little about the effects of election dates on the electoral process itself. Before proceeding, advocates, skeptics, and others interested in improving American democracy should know the effect fewer elections has on the electoral experience.

This paper studies the effects of on-cycle elections on three key elements of the electoral experience: the opinions of election administrators, objective indicators of election quality, and surveys of the voting experience. Utilizing original panel data on election timing both nationwide and for California and Florida, we find that switching to on-cycle elections 1) reduces the burden on election officials, 2) has a limited impact on election quality, and 3) does not substantially degrade the voters’ experience, with the exception of slightly increased wait times at the polls. Taken together, our findings should provide reassurance that the rapid movement across states to consolidate local and federal elections will not substantially degrade the quality of election administration.

2 Data and Research Design

We collect original state-level panel data on election timing laws from 2010 to 2024. The panel is based on Anzia (2013) and is supplemented with yearly updates from the National Conference of State Legislators, Ballotpedia, and other online sources. States are coded on a 0–1 scale with 0 indicating local elections are required to be off-cycle and 1 indicating that they are required to be on-cycle. States where localities can choose their own dates are coded as $\frac{1}{3}$ if most localities have chosen off-cycle elections or as $\frac{2}{3}$ if most localities hold on-cycle elections. Supplementary tests that use a binary variable to distinguish between states that mandate on-cycle elections and all others are displayed in the online appendix. We also focus on two individual states that allow cities to switch their own timing and have recently experienced significant variation in election timing: California (2000–2022) and Florida (2008–2018).² Because election administration in these states is at the county level, we calculate the percentage of cities in each county-year that hold local elections concurrently with state and federal elections.

²California is particularly of interest because much of its recent variation in election timing is exogenous to indicators of election quality in general elections. SB 415—the California Voter Participation Rights Act, enacted in 2015, required most cities to move to on-cycle elections.

We compile a wide range of panel data from administrative and survey sources to test the effects of on-cycle elections on election administrators, election quality, and the voter experience. We collect information on election officials by combining the 2019, 2020, and 2023 waves of the Early Voting Information Center’s Survey of Local Election Officials.³ These include questions on workload, funding, staffing, job satisfaction, job goals, and support for election date consolidation.

We use five objective measures to assess local election administration quality for federal general elections: voter turnout, residual vote, provisional vote rate, absentee rejection rate, and the incidence of reporting errors. Data on voter turnout is from Dave Leip’s Atlas of U.S. Elections and spans 2000 to 2024. We calculate turnout using highest-office vote counts for the numerator (president in years divisible by four and governor or senator in other even years) and number of voting-age residents in the denominator.⁴ Residual vote and reporting errors are also calculated from Leip data. Residual vote is measured as the share of ballots cast without a vote for highest office (Kropf et al. 2020; Stewart et al. 2020). In difference-in-difference estimators, high residual vote rates can signal errors in election administration, such as poor ballot design or poorly maintained election equipment. A county is coded as having a reporting error when it has a negative residual vote, or in other words when more votes are reported for highest office than for overall turnout. Data on provisional ballots cast and absentee ballots rejected is from the U.S. Election Assistance Commission’s biannual Election Administration and Voting Surveys (EAVS) and span 2004 to 2024.⁵ High rates of provisional voting and rejected absentee ballots can also indicate errors in election administration, such as inadequate election worker training and communication to voters. We calculate the provisional ballot rate as the share of total ballots that were cast provisionally. Absentee rejection rate is calculated as the share of absentee ballots that were rejected.

³https://evic.reed.edu/previous_leo_surveys/

⁴We rely on county-level estimates from the National Cancer Institute’s Surveillance, Epidemiology and End Results Program available at <https://seer.cancer.gov/popdata/singleages.html>.

⁵<https://www.eac.gov/research-and-data/datasets-codebooks-and-surveys-old>

Finally, we capture data on voters’ experiences at the polls using the 2014, 2016, 2020, and 2022 waves of the Survey of the Performance of American Elections.⁶ Each survey typically interviews 200 residents of each U.S. state.⁷ We focus on three key indicators: self-reports of problems encountered while voting, voter wait times at the polls, and voter confidence in elections.

Our main estimation strategy is differences-in-differences, using unit and time fixed effects to measure the effect of a change from off-cycle to on-cycle local elections on the electoral experience for voters and administrators. Administrator attitudes are measured at the election-jurisdiction level.⁸ Election quality outcomes are measured at the county-year level. Voter experience outcomes are individual survey responses, with individual controls (age, gender, race, education, income, and party identification) and county and year fixed effects. In all specifications, treatment varies at the state level, so standard errors are clustered by state throughout.

We validate our main findings of the causal effect of on-cycle elections on election quality and voter experience in three ways: with Callaway and Sant’Anna Event Study estimators in Section A.3.1, which validate the parallel trends assumption and account for heterogeneous treatment effects (Callaway and Sant’Anna 2021; de Chaisemartin and D’Haultfoeuille 2020); with randomization inference in Section A.3.2, which assess robustness to the small number of treated clusters; and with generalized synthetic control in Section A.3.3 (Xu 2017), which constructs a counterfactual for each treated state using interactive fixed effects.⁹

⁶<https://electionlab.mit.edu/research/projects/survey-performance-american-elections>

⁷We weight our regressions using SPAE data by the survey weights provided by the survey team. These weights are constructed using propensity scores to match a sampling frame of the U.S. adult population balanced on gender, age, race, education, and presidential vote choice.

⁸Election jurisdictions are at the county level in 41 states. They are at the municipal level for eight states: Connecticut, Maine, Massachusetts, Michigan, New Hampshire, Rhode Island, Vermont, and Wisconsin. Elections are administered at the regional level in Alaska.

⁹We are unable to conduct these tests for our findings on election administrators due to a lack of variation in the binary measure of election timing for the available data. We are only able to conduct generalized synthetic control for measures of election quality due to the lengthy pre-treatment data required for the method.

3 Analysis

Election consolidation could have widely divergent effects. Reducing the number of elections could make life easier for voters (who have to travel to the polls less) and for election administrators (who have to prepare for fewer elections). But putting all or most of America’s electoral contests on the same ballot on the same day could also cause confusion and extra burdens for all involved. In extreme cases, voters could be asked to make choices across hundreds of divergent contests on a ballot that could spill across several pages. Likewise, election administrators will need to work through the complexities of a longer ballot that incorporates a range of different jurisdictions running different types of elections. If as the Kansas Secretary of State’s office predicts, the number of on-cycle contests “exponentially increases” it is not clear if voters and election officials can handle it (Smith 2026).

3.1 Do On-Cycle Elections Impact Election Administrators?

We begin with election administrators as they are the actors who actually run the election and may face the biggest burden during the transition to on-cycle elections. Our analysis of administrator views—which is displayed in Table 1—suggests that the move to on-cycle elections sharply reduces the burden on election officials.¹⁰ The diff-in-diff model indicates that shifting on-cycle leads to a sharp reduction in their workload. Election administrators report a 37% increase in the reasonableness of their workload. This is equivalent to moving their answer from “neither agreeing nor disagreeing” that their workload is reasonable to agreeing that it is. Administrators might worry that the reduced workload leads to a reduction in funding and support. While the latter appears to be true—we imprecisely estimate the average jurisdiction shedding 1.5 FTEs upon the move to on-cycle local elections (column 3)—administrators also become much more likely to report that the funding they receive is

¹⁰We are unable to replicate these results with the binary measure of on-cycle elections or conduct additional validation exercises due to the lack of variation in this dependent variable over the 2019 to 2023 survey period used in this analysis.

sufficient to do their job (column 2). The reduction in FTEs can explain studies finding cost savings in the move to on-cycle elections (Durning 2023).

Table 1: **Effect of On-Cycle Elections on Election Official Attitudes**

	Workload reasonable (1)	Funding sufficient (2)	FTEs (3)	Sense of accomplish (4)	Job turnout (5)	Job dispar (6)	Support for consolidation (7)
On-Cycle	1.146 (0.343)	1.557 (0.277)	-1.504 (1.683)	1.346 (0.084)	1.292 (0.303)	0.537 (0.216)	1.461 (0.466)
Years	3	3	3	3	3	3	3
Observations	2103	2106	2086	1889	1921	2086	2099
Outcome Mean	3.10	3.26	5.94	4.51	3.78	3.47	3.48
Jurisdiction FEs	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year FEs	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Individual Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Robust standard errors clustered by state in parentheses. Data is from the 2019, 2020, and 2023 EVIC Survey of Local Election Officials. Individual controls are total number of registered voters in election jurisdiction and the age, gender, race, education, and salary of the election official. Column 1 is from the question: “My workload is reasonable”. Column 2 is reverse-coded from the question: “A lack of sufficient funding often prevents me from doing my job well.” Column 3 measures full-time equivalents, which is derived from taking the midpoint values of FTE ranges. Column 4 is from the question: “My work gives me a feeling of personal accomplishment.” Column 5 is from the question: “It is part of my job to encourage voter turnout.” Column 6 is from the question: “Local election officials should work to reduce demographic disparities in voter turnout.” Column 7 is from the question: “Consolidate local, state, and federal elections to take place at the same time.” Besides for FTEs, all questions are on a 1-5 Likert scale ranging from “strongly disagree” to “strongly agree.”

One net effect of all of this is a greater sense of accomplishment among election officials (column 4). After the move to on-cycle elections, administrators are also able to focus more on raising voter turnout (column 5) and reducing demographic disparities in voter turnout (column 6).

Finally, we examine whether administrators’ experience running on-cycle elections leads to changes in how they view election consolidation. Across the nation, local election official support for consolidation is broad. In each year of the Local Election Official Survey, slightly over half of all respondents support consolidating local, state, and federal elections. Only about 20 percent express opposition each year. Experience with on-cycle elections increases that already high level of support. Our diff-in-diff analysis suggests that support for consolidated elections grows substantially in jurisdictions that have recently experienced the transition to on-cycle elections than it does in jurisdictions that have not. The effect

is equivalent to moving from “Neither support or oppose” election consolidation to halfway between “support” and “strongly support”. This is unlikely to be contaminated by reverse causality, since local election officials typically have limited sway in the decision of state lawmakers to move local elections on-cycle. The fact that the officials who oversee elections are more enthusiastic about on-cycle elections after running those consolidated elections is telling.

3.2 Do On-Cycle Elections Impact Election Quality?

In this section we evaluate the impact of election timing on the quality of election administration. In Table 2 we assess five objective metrics of election quality and performance: voter turnout, residual vote rate, provisional vote rate, absentee rejection rate, and outcome reporting errors.¹¹ The analysis reveals no significant change in election quality on most of the measures we examine. There is no consistent evidence that provisional vote rates increase, no sign of gains in absentee rejection rates, and no rise in the incidence of reporting errors when election dates are consolidated. These null effects are evident at both the national level and in the Florida and California analysis. Across most indicators of election quality, on-cycle elections mirror off-cycle elections. We find consistent results using an alternative binary measure of on-cycle timing for the national panel, shown in Table A.1 in the online appendix.

The only metric for which there might be a reduction in election performance is the residual vote rate. The national analysis suggests that consolidated elections may have a higher incidence of voters leaving the top of the ticket blank. This effect is statistically significant for our four-part measure of on-cycle, although not for the binary measure. It is not replicated in the state-level analyses. Taken together, it does not appear that consolidating election dates has any significant negative impact on election quality.

¹¹This analysis excludes eight states that administer elections at the borough or municipal level: Alaska, Connecticut, Massachusetts, Maine, New Hampshire, Rhode Island, Vermont, and Wisconsin.

Election performance may improve in one way. Consolidated general elections—at least in the national analysis—tend to have higher turnout than unconsolidated elections. This suggests that adding lower tier local contests to a general election can increase turnout in higher profile federal contests for president and Congress. Should we really expect the addition of a city council or school board contest to a presidential ballot to increase participation in the presidential contest? Perhaps so (Phillips 2020). While local level contests gain relatively little national attention, for the candidates themselves and for many of the residents who vote in those lower tier contests, it matters who wins and who loses those contests. Because candidates for local office often work hard to bring their voters to the ballot box, it might not be unreasonable to expect their efforts to mobilize a small set of locally engaged residents who may not always participate in national contests. The estimated effect size is 2.2 percentage point increase in turnout in general federal contests. That parallels analysis by the Indiana Secretary of State which showed that 1-2% of off-cycle municipal voters failed to participate in the state’s subsequent on-cycle federal contest (Morales 2025). However, the effect is not statistically significant and we uncover no similar increase in turnout in the California and Florida analysis, indicating that further testing is required.¹²

¹²Using a binary measure of on-cycle elections in Table A.1 yields a 0.6 percentage point increase in turnout that is also statistically indistinguishable from zero.

Table 2: **Effect of On-Cycle Elections on Election Quality**

	Voter turnout (1)	Residual vote (2)	Provisional rate (3)	Absentee reject rate (4)	Reporting error (5)
<i>Panel A: National</i>					
On-Cycle	0.022 (0.012)	0.009 (0.003)	0.010 (0.011)	0.011 (0.008)	-0.032 (0.033)
Counties	2918	2514	2874	2918	2601
Years	8	8	8	8	8
Observations	18747	15272	21039	21931	16138
Outcome Mean	0.53	0.01	0.01	0.02	0.01
<i>Panel B: California</i>					
On-Cycle Percent	0.006 (0.006)	0.003 (0.002)	-0.013 (0.013)	-0.019 (0.016)	
Counties	52	52	52	52	
Years	12	12	8	10	
Observations	624	624	414	495	
Outcome Mean	0.45	0.02	0.04	0.02	
<i>Panel C: Florida</i>					
On-Cycle Percent	0.005 (0.009)	0.000 (0.001)	-0.000 (0.000)	-0.003 (0.002)	0.011 (0.011)
Counties	50	50	50	50	50
Years	6	6	6	6	6
Observations	300	300	300	299	300
Outcome Mean	0.52	0.01	0.00	0.01	0.00
Jurisdiction FEs	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year FEs	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Robust standard errors clustered by state (Panel A) or jurisdiction (Panels B-C) in parentheses. Turnout is measured as the share of voting-age residents who cast a vote in the presidential race for presidential years and the gubernatorial race for midterm years. Residual vote is measured as the share of ballots cast without a vote for president in presidential years and for governor in midterm years. Provisional ballot rate is measured as the share of ballots cast as provisionals. Absentee ballot rejection rate is the share of absentee ballots that are rejected. Reporting errors are when a county has a negative residual vote, or in other words when more votes are reported for highest office than for overall turnout. David Leip's U.S. Election Atlas provides turnout and election outcome data used to calculate residual vote and reporting errors. Provisionals and absentee ballot rejection rates are from the U.S. Election Assistance Commission's EAVS reports. There is no output in Column 5 for California because of a lack of variation on the dependent variable: no counties in the state have a reporting error between 2000 and 2022.

3.3 Do On-Cycle Elections Impact the Voting Experience?

The results so far suggest that shifting to on-cycle elections has few negative effects and may in fact lead to reduced burdens on administrators. But we have not yet assessed the principal actors in democracy: the voters themselves. To best gauge the impact of on-cycle elections, we need to know how changes in election dates alter the experience of voters. To assess those experiences we turn to the four most recent waves of the Survey of the Performance of American Elections with county identifiers—a national survey of registered voters designed to offer insight into the voting process.

Even though consolidated elections add more contests, there is little sign in Table 3 that on-cycle elections degrade the voter’s experience (results using a binary measure of on-cycle elections can be found in Table A.4 in the Online Appendix). As the table indicates, Americans who vote on-cycle are not more likely to report problems in the voting process. They report slightly longer waits at the polls—4.6 additional minutes, on average—and the effect is statistically significant ($p \leq .01$). However, their trust in the electoral process does not change. Moving on-cycle does not have a statistically significant effect on their trust in the efficacy of their own vote or their trust in the efficacy of the national electoral process (in Tables A.2 and A.5 in the Online Appendix, we also show that moving on-cycle does not significantly affect voters’ trust in their county and state vote as well).

Nevertheless, any increase in the costs of voting—no matter how small—is something that legislators should consider incorporating into their legislative plans. Wherever election consolidation is being contemplated, legislators should consider tools to make voting easier, incentives to spur ballot-design improvements, and additional financial support to the local administrators tasked with implementing consolidated elections (Ketcham and Severns 2024). These additional measures, which might include more voting equipment, more poll workers, more polling locations, and greater access to early voting and absentee voting options, could be funded by funneling some of the substantial cost savings of on-cycle elections back into the elections themselves.

Table 3: **Effect of On-Cycle Elections on The Voter Experience**

	Problem	Wait (min)	Voter Confidence	
	(1)	(2)	Own	Nation
	(3)	(4)		
On-Cycle	-0.000 (0.006)	4.616 (1.482)	-0.070 (0.037)	0.066 (0.047)
Years	4	4	4	4
Observations	47968	27891	41717	45861
Outcome Mean	0.04	9.89	0.71	0.34
County FEs	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year FEs	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Individual Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Robust standard errors clustered by state in parentheses. Estimates are weighted by SPAE survey weights. Individual controls are age, gender, race, education, income, and party identity. Data from the 2014, 2016, 2020, and 2022 waves of the Survey of the Performance of American Elections.

4 Discussion

The rapid adoption of on-cycle elections across the country raises real concerns for the electoral process. Aligning different electoral contests on the same day both lengthens and complicates the ballot—two changes that could challenge voters and election officials. At the same time, with more contests decided on one day, it raises the stakes to get things right and the consequences for administrative errors. The analysis presented in this article suggests that these concerns are largely unwarranted. On almost all measures, we find that moving on-cycle has no negative effects on election administrators, on voters, and on the electoral process, with the possible exception of a small increase in wait times. We uncover one positive attribute: by reducing the number of election dates, on-cycle elections significantly reduce the burden on election administrators. That reduced workload allows election officials to focus more of their time and energy on core democratic outcomes like increasing turnout and making the electorate more representative of the underlying population. The net result is few discernible changes in election performance metrics and a strikingly similar voting

experience for individual voters. It might even cause a slight increase in voter turnout in national general elections, though more research on this effect is warranted.

These findings are important because they address one of the most important concerns related to election date consolidation (Smith 2026). What we learn here – that elections run as smoothly when elections are consolidated – tells us that the previously documented turnout (Marschall and Lappie 2025; Phillips 2020), representational (Hajnal, Kogan, and Markarian 2022), and cost-saving (Durning 2023) benefits to on-cycle elections are not offset by major declines in the electoral process itself. We do uncover marginal increases in voter wait times and the provisional vote rate that warrant further attention. But this could be ameliorated by using the money saved in staff reduction from consolidating election dates to purchase more voting equipment, hire more poll workers, and extend early voting hours around the consolidated elections.

These findings are also important because election consolidation has enormous potential to impact almost all aspects of the local democratic process. Moving to on-cycle presidential dates has a major impact on turnout for local offices– doubling or more than doubling participation (Anzia 2013; de Benedictis-Kessner et al. 2023; Marschall and Lappie 2025). Moving to consolidated elections is the single most important change that reformers can undertake to increase turnout in local contests. That means that by moving on-cycle, states like Arizona, California, Nevada, New York, Virginia, and West Virginia will likely add more than 10 million new voters to local democracy by the time those reforms are fully implemented. Los Angeles alone added more than half a million voters when that city held its first November even year mayoral contest in 2022.¹³

There is also little doubt that the move to on-cycle dates changes who votes more than other reforms. The fact that on-cycle elections greatly increase the share of local voters who are young and who are Americans of color means that a move on-cycle makes local democracy more representative of local communities (Hajnal, Kogan, and Markarian 2022).

¹³<https://laist.com/news/politics/turnout-la-mayoral-race-2022>

The net effect is a local government that is also more representative of the local population and policies that are more in line with the median resident (Dynes, Hartney, and Hayes 2021; Hajnal, Kogan, and Markarian 2025). In short, future changes in election timing could have a dramatic impact on local democracy.

These findings also matter because more election timing reform is likely. Despite recent reforms around the country, most of America remains off-cycle (de Benedictis-Kessner et al. 2023; Durning 2023). Over 60 percent of America’s local elections are still held off-cycle, where turnout is exceptionally low and extremely skewed (de Benedictis-Kessner et al. 2023; Hajnal, Kogan, and Markarian 2022). If legislators continue the trend of having Americans vote once in on-cycle elections rather than voting on different dates for different offices, then it will no doubt transform local democracy (Anzia 2013; Ketcham and Severns 2024).

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Online Appendix

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A.1 Additional Election Quality Results

Table 2 in the main text tested the effect of switching to on-cycle on five measurable indicators of election quality: voter turnout, residual vote, provisional rate, absentee rejection rate, and the incidence of reporting errors. Table A.1 replicates these regressions using a binary measure of on-cycle municipal elections, with states coded as 1 if they mandate on-cycle timing and 0 otherwise. The results are in line with those shown in the main text. Voter turnout increases, but the effect cannot be confidently distinguished from a null effect. There is no effect of switching to on-cycle elections on the residual vote rate or the incidence of reporting errors. We do see two diverging effects: a statistically significant decrease in the rate at which provisional ballots are cast, and a statistically significant increase in the absentee rejection rate. Combined with the state-specific findings, we take this as further evidence that consolidating election dates does not systematically degrade the quality of election administration.

Table A.1: **Effect of On-Cycle Elections on Election Quality - Binary Measure**

	Voter turnout (1)	Residual vote (2)	Provisional rate (3)	Absentee reject rate (4)	Reporting error (5)
On-Cycle Mandated	0.006 (0.008)	0.004 (0.002)	-0.007 (0.004)	0.007 (0.005)	-0.011 (0.013)
Counties	2918	2514	2874	2918	2601
Years	8	8	8	8	8
Observations	18747	15272	21039	21931	16138
Outcome Mean	0.53	0.01	0.01	0.02	0.01
Jurisdiction FEs	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year FEs	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Robust standard errors clustered by state in parentheses. On-cycle Mandated is coded as 1 if the state requires municipalities to hold their elections on-cycle, and 0 otherwise. Turnout is measured as the share of voting-age residents who cast a vote in the presidential race for presidential years and the gubernatorial race for midterm years. Residual vote is measured as the share of ballots cast without a vote for president in presidential years and for governor in midterm years. Provisional ballot rate is measured as the share of ballots cast as provisionals. Absentee ballot rejection rate is the share of absentee ballots that are rejected. Reporting errors are when a county has a negative residual vote, or in other words when more votes are reported for highest office than for overall turnout. David Leip's U.S. Election Atlas provides turnout and election outcome data used to calculate residual vote and reporting errors. Provisionals and absentee ballot rejection rates are from the U.S. Election Assistance Commission's EAVS reports.

A.2 Additional Voter Experience Results

Table A.2 shows tabular results for the right panel of Figure ?? in the main analysis, estimating the effect of on-cycle elections on the average voters' wait time.

Table A.2: **Effect of On-Cycle Elections on Voter Confidence**

	Very Confident Vote Counted Correctly			
	Own Vote	County Vote	State Vote	National Vote
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
On-Cycle	-0.070 (0.037)	-0.024 (0.030)	-0.037 (0.042)	0.066 (0.047)
Years	4	4	4	4
Observations	41717	46011	45986	45861
Outcome Mean	0.71	0.61	0.52	0.34
County FEs	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year FEs	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Individual Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Robust standard errors clustered by state in parentheses. Estimates are weighted by SPAE survey weights. Individual controls are age, gender, race, education, income, and party identity.

In Table 3 of the main analysis, we estimate the effect of jurisdictions switching to on-cycle municipal elections on voters' confidence that their own vote and their national vote is counted correctly. Table A.3 expands that analysis to include voters' county vote (column 2) and state vote (column 3). The results are similarly null.

Tables A.4, A.5, and A.6 replicate Tables 3, A.2, and A.3, respectively, substituting a binary measure of on-cycle elections. The results mostly align with those from our preferred four-part measure of on-cycle elections. The only notable divergence is the findings for wait times. The overall estimated effect on wait times is negative rather than positive and not statistically distinguishable from zero. While the binary measure of on-cycle elections yields a statistically significant increase in the percentage of people reporting a 10 to 30 minute wait, there is an equivalent statistically significant decrease in the percentage of people who report a wait of 30 to 60 minutes.

Table A.3: **Effect of On-Cycle Elections on Voter Wait Times**

	No Wait (1)	Wait 0-10 min (2)	Wait 10-30 min (3)	Wait 30-60 min (4)	Wait > 1 hr (5)
On-Cycle	-0.103 (0.020)	-0.020 (0.064)	0.574 (1.034)	1.454 (0.701)	3.916 (1.694)
Years	4	4	4	4	4
Observations	27891	27891	27891	27891	27891
Outcome Mean	0.44	0.44	9.89	9.89	9.89
County FEs	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year FEs	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Individual Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Robust standard errors clustered by state in parentheses. Estimates are weighted by SPAE survey weights. Individual controls are age, gender, race, education, income, and party identity.

Table A.4: **Effect of On-Cycle Elections on The Voter Experience - Binary Measure**

	Problem (1)	Wait (min) (2)	Voter Confidence Own (3)	Nation (4)
On-Cycle Mandated	-0.002 (0.011)	0.574 (1.034)	-0.033 (0.032)	0.043 (0.033)
Years	4	4	4	4
Observations	47968	27891	41717	45861
Outcome Mean	0.04	9.89	0.71	0.34
County FEs	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year FEs	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Individual Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Robust standard errors clustered by state in parentheses. On-cycle Mandated is coded as 1 if the state requires municipalities to hold their elections on-cycle, and 0 otherwise. Estimates are weighted by SPAE survey weights. Individual controls are age, gender, race, education, income, and party identity. Data from the 2014, 2016, 2020, and 2022 waves of the Survey of the Performance of American Elections.

Table A.5: **Effect of On-Cycle Elections on Voter Confidence - Binary Measure**

	Very Confident Vote Counted Correctly			
	Own Vote	County Vote	State Vote	National Vote
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
On-Cycle Mandated	-0.033 (0.032)	-0.011 (0.019)	-0.009 (0.020)	0.043 (0.033)
Years	4	4	4	4
Observations	41717	46011	45986	45861
Outcome Mean	0.71	0.61	0.52	0.34
County FEs	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year FEs	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Individual Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Robust standard errors clustered by state in parentheses. On-cycle Mandated is coded as 1 if the state requires municipalities to hold their elections on-cycle, and 0 otherwise. Estimates are weighted by SPAE survey weights. Individual controls are age, gender, race, education, income, and party identity.

Table A.6: **Effect of On-Cycle Elections on Voter Wait Times - Binary Measure**

	No Wait	Wait 0-10 min	Wait 10-30 min	Wait 30-60 min	Wait > 1 hr
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
On-Cycle Mandated	-0.020 (0.064)	0.008 (0.066)	0.031 (0.011)	-0.036 (0.011)	0.017 (0.016)
Years	4	4	4	4	4
Observations	27891	27891	27891	27891	27891
Outcome Mean	0.44	0.31	0.16	0.06	0.02
County FEs	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year FEs	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Individual Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Robust standard errors clustered by state in parentheses. On-cycle Mandated is coded as 1 if the state requires municipalities to hold their elections on-cycle, and 0 otherwise. Estimates are weighted by SPAE survey weights. Individual controls are age, gender, race, education, income, and party identity.

A.3 DID Robustness Tests

A.3.1 Callaway and Sant’Anna Event Study

This section reports the results of the Callaway and Sant’Anna (2021) dynamic difference-in-difference estimator. This removes potential bias in staggered treatment DID designs due to heterogeneous effects across units or time (Callaway and Sant’Anna 2021; de Chaisemartin and D’Haultfœuille 2020; Goodman-Bacon 2021). The estimator is run with year fixed effects, with cohort measured as the first year each state switches to on-cycle municipal elections. Pre-trends for voter experience outcomes are not generated due to the short time window of data availability: only 1 year is covered by multiple treated cohorts.

Table A.7: **Callaway–Sant’Anna Estimates: Effect of Moving On-Cycle on Election Quality (Balanced Event Window)**

	Voter Turnout (1)	Residual Vote Rate (2)	Provisional Vote Rate (3)	Absentee Rejection Rate (4)	Reporting Errors (5)
Overall ATT	0.011 (0.020)	0.005 (0.004)	0.009 (0.028)	0.010 (0.011)	-0.011 (0.008)
Event window	[-4, 2]	[-4, 2]	[-4, 2]	[-4, 2]	[-4, 2]
Counties	2683	2279	2639	2683	2366

Doubly robust Callaway and Sant’Anna estimates with never-treated states as the control group; standard errors clustered by state, bootstrapped with 1,000 iterations. Treatment is a state’s move to on-cycle local elections, adopted by California (2015), Arizona (2016), and Nevada (2022). Four states with on-cycle elections throughout the panel (AR, HI, KY, OR) are excluded, as they provide no pre-treatment variation. The ATT is aggregated over the event-time window in which at least 2 treated cohorts are observed, matching the window shown in the corresponding dynamic figure.

Figure A.1: **Callaway and Sant’Anna Dynamic Effects Estimation of On-Cycle Elections on Election Quality.** This shows the effect of a switch to on-cycle municipal elections on election quality. States that always have on-cycle elections are filtered out. The sample is filtered to years when at least two treated states are observed. Point estimates are relative to the difference in election workload between jurisdictions in states that switch to on-cycle municipal elections and those that do not in the year prior to the reform. Error bars reflect 95% confidence intervals.

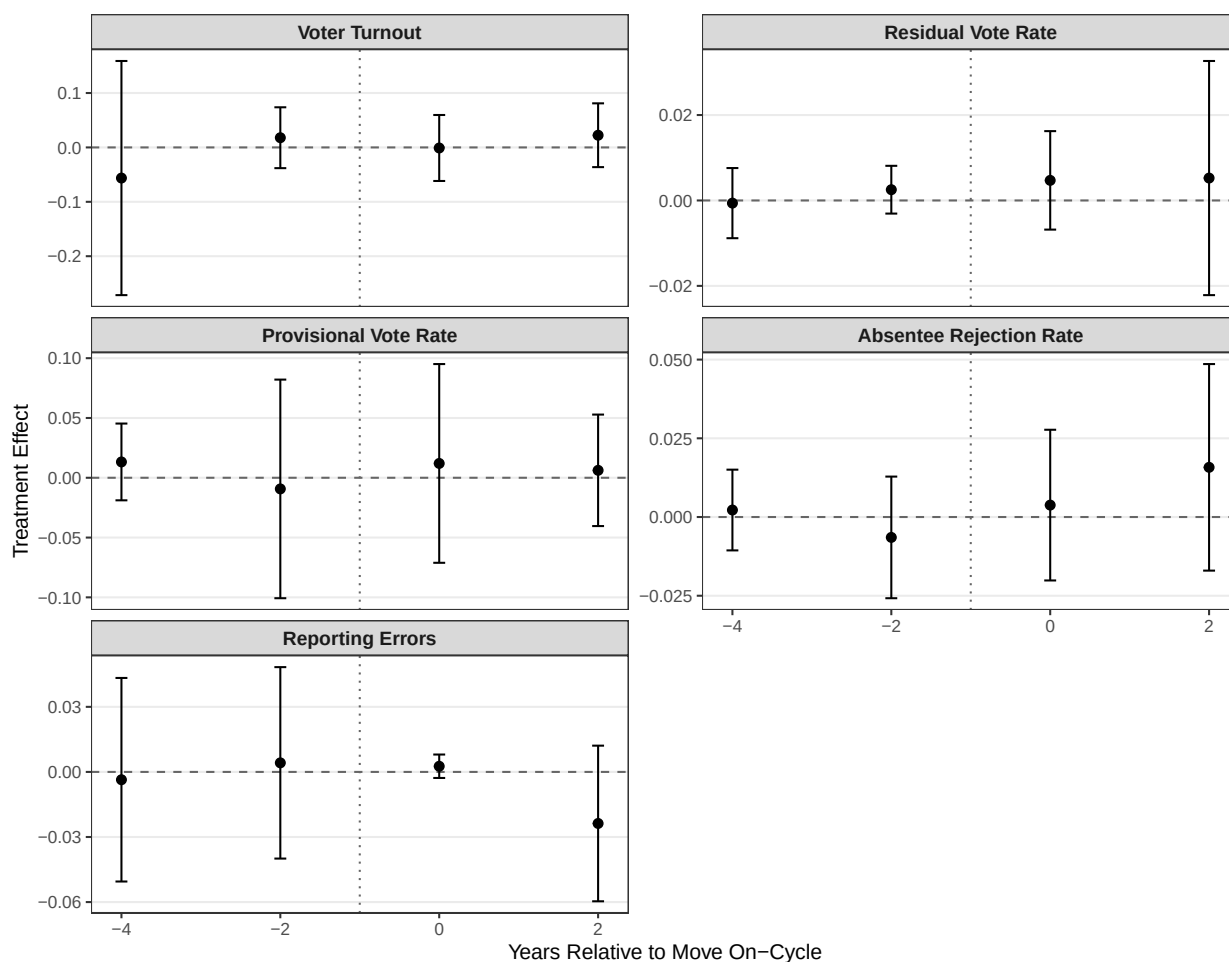


Table A.8: **Callaway–Sant’Anna Estimates: Effect of Moving On-Cycle on Voter Experience (Balanced Event Window)**

	Reported Problem Voting (1)	Wait Time (Minutes) (2)	Confidence: Own Vote (3)	Confidence: National Vote (4)
Overall ATT	-0.030 (0.026)	3.449 (6.060)	0.093 (0.197)	0.046 (0.119)
Event window	[0, 0]	[0, 0]	[0, 0]	[0, 0]
Counties	2383	2181	2325	2365

Doubly robust Callaway and Sant’Anna estimates with never-treated states as the control group; standard errors clustered by state, bootstrapped with 1,000 iterations. Treatment is a state’s move to on-cycle local elections, adopted by California (2015), Arizona (2016), and Nevada (2022). Four states with on-cycle elections throughout the panel (AR, HI, KY, OR) are excluded, as they provide no pre-treatment variation. The ATT is aggregated over the event-time window in which at least 2 treated cohorts are observed, matching the window shown in the corresponding dynamic figure. Estimated on county-year means of survey responses, residualized on respondent demographics (age, gender, race, education, income, and party identification) and weighted by SPAE survey weights. Time is indexed by survey wave, not calendar year, because the SPAE is not fielded in every even year.

A.3.2 Randomization Inference

Figure A.2: **Randomization Inference for Effect of On-Cycle Elections on Election Quality.** This graph displays the output of randomization inference for the effect of switching to on-cycle elections on election quality. Which states receive treatment is randomly permuted, preserving the timing pattern of treatment. The black distributions shows the resulting coefficients of 1,000 iterations. The red solid vertical line is the actual coefficient observed, and the p-value is the share of coefficients that are equal to or larger than absolute value of the one estimated in the respective specification.

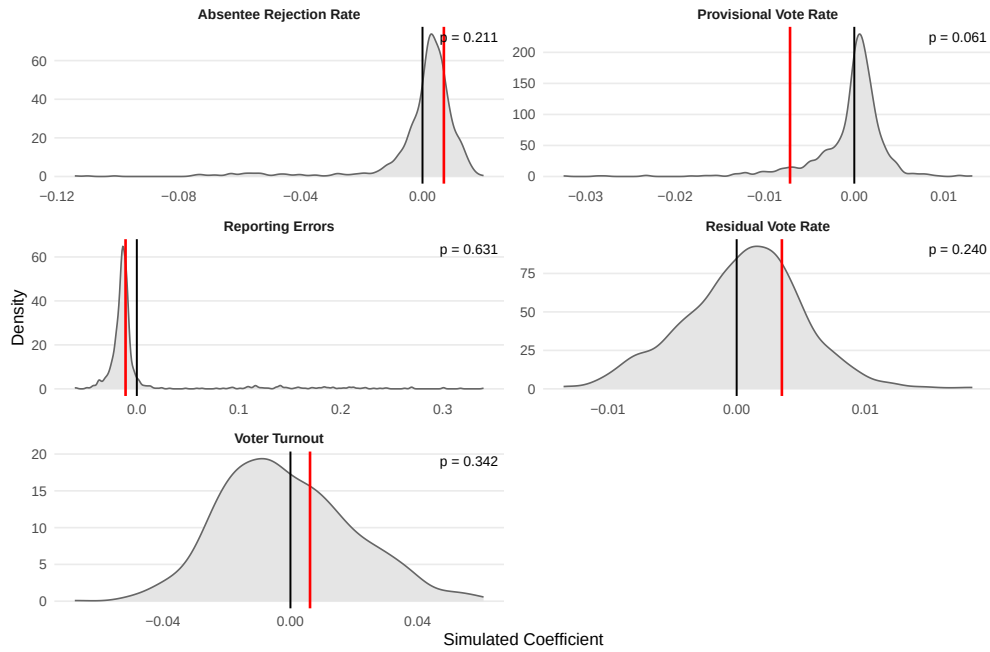
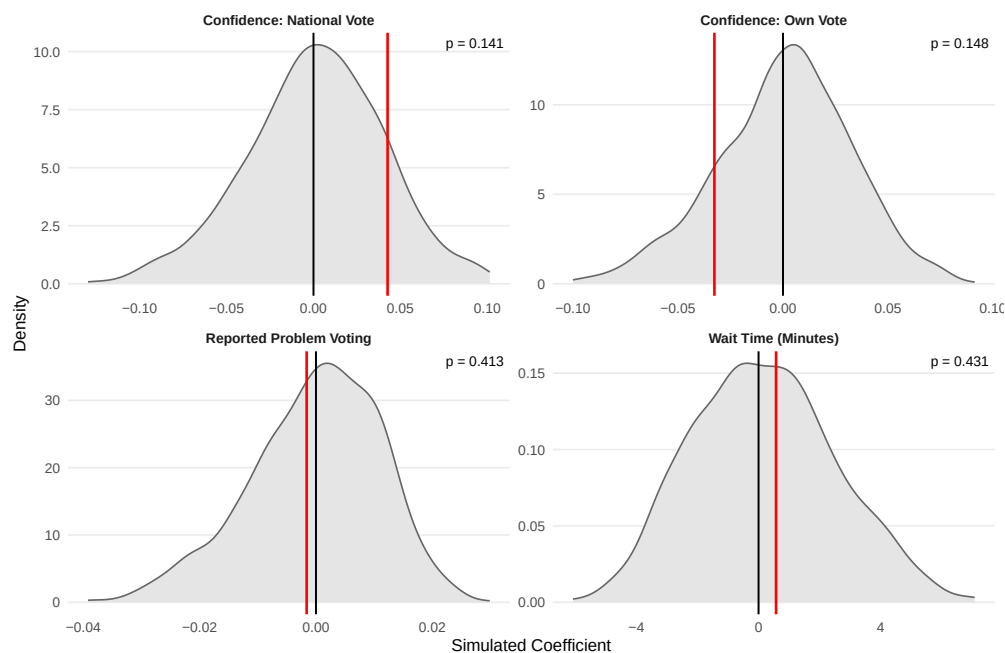


Figure A.3: **Randomization Inference for Effect of On-Cycle Elections on The Voter Experience.** This graph displays the output of randomization inference for the effect of switching to on-cycle elections on the voter experience. Which states receive treatment is randomly permuted, preserving the timing pattern of treatment. Each specification controls for respondent demographics (age, gender, race, education, income, and party identification) and is weighted by SPAE survey weights, matching the corresponding published model. The black distributions shows the resulting coefficients of 1,000 iterations. The red solid vertical line is the actual coefficient observed, and the p-value is the share of coefficients that are equal to or larger than absolute value of the one estimated in the respective specification.



A.3.3 Generalized Synthetic Control

Figure A.4: **Estimated ATT of Generalized Synthetic Control.** This figure displays generalized synthetic control estimates of the effect of switching to on-cycle municipal elections on election quality. Outcomes are aggregated to the state-year level (unweighted county means), since treatment is assigned at the state level; the three treated states are California (2015), Arizona (2016), and Nevada (2022). Four states that are always on-cycle (AR, HI, KY, OR) are excluded from the donor pool. The specification includes additive state and year fixed effects, with standard errors from a parametric bootstrap of 1,000 samples. The black line is the estimated gap between each treated state and its synthetic counterfactual by year, and the band is a 95% confidence interval.

